DE GRUYTER MOUTON INTERNATIONAL JOURNAL OF THE SOCIOLOGY OF LANGUAGE IJSL 2014; 229: 67–94

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A brown man's burden: critiquing an American restorationist discourse

Abstract: The American-born Stone-Campbell Movement, particularly its ecclesiastical offshoot, the Church/es of Christ, is one of the religious projects which was exported to the Philippines along with the U.S.A.'s colonial mission in Asia. Operating on a "restorationist" theological framework, it seeks a return to a "New Testament Christianity" uncorrupted by denominationalism. This article proposes that the Church of Christ version of restorationism demonstrates the nature of discourse, in the Foucauldian sense – i.e., totalizing and regulative set of pronouncements and practices which provides for its own subversion and overthrow. It attempts to show how, in its interface with the culture of the Igorots of Northern Philippines, it assumes a form of cultural imperialism which marginalizes the indigenous while spelling its own alienation with its West-centric orientation and ecclesiocentric language. The study is framed not only by its appropriation of Foucault's notion of discourse and of several Filipino missiologists' concept of "indigenized/contextualized theology," but also by the author's former subjection to the religious discourse under question. It joins the call for a continuous interrogation of Western religious discourses imposed upon or coopted by Philippine and other Asian societies with the end view of fostering interethnic dialogue and understanding between and among Asian and non-Asian cultures.

Keywords: restorationism, Churches of Christ, discourse, ecclesiology, American exceptionalism

DOI 10.1515/ijsl-2014-0018

1 Introduction

Sharon Delmendo asserts in her incisive work, *The star-entangled banner: One hundred years of America in the Philippines*: "Despite fifty years of putative Filipino independence, the United States continues to exert a dominating influence on

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the Philippines" (2005: 119). What she observed about the economic and political realities of Philippine society holds true to Protestant/Evangelical Christianity in the country. For as noted Filipino theologian Ed Lapiz pointed out:

> For almost a hundred years now, evangelical Christianity in the Philippines has almost always been equated with Westernization or, more exactly, Americanization. For instance, a Christian should only be singing formal Western Music at church (the lyrics may sometimes be localized, though) or recently, doing an American gospel song. Filipino Christian worship has been mindlessly structured after Western prototypes without regard for indigenous – and still very much alive – Filipino concepts of time, space, spirituality, and community. Of course, all these encroachments were done in the high name of evangelization. Inasmuch as the indigenous culture has been collectively adjudged "evil," "pagan," "animist," etc. by many foreign missionaries, it was deemed but proper to destroy and replace it with a "sacred" one; never mind if the replacement is not even the New Testament Eastern-type of Christianity that we see in the Book of Acts but just a version, among many versions: the Anglo-American form. (Lapiz 1997: xiii)

Thus, he says, there is a need "to examine, investigate and criticize the way of teaching Christianity that needlessly tramples upon the culture of the recipients" (Lapiz 1997: 100; cf. 2010: 1–4).

This article seeks to contribute to addressing that need by interrogating the doctrines and practices of the (Stone-Campbell) *Church of Christ*, especially in relation to the place of Philippine indigenous culture in its theological system. This work is informed by the author's ten years of hyperactive involvement in the various ecclesiastical programs of this religious group, a reading of its polemical works representing several positions along its peculiar conservative-liberal theological spectrum, the postcolonial thoughts mainly of Philippine theologians and missiologists, as well as Michel Foucault's (1972) notion of discourse.

Among all the Protestant/Evangelical groups in the Philippines, the *Church/es of Christ* (CoC) is unique due to its adherence to an American patternistic theology encapsulated in a three-pronged hermeneutic – i.e., explicit command, example and necessary inference, or "CENI" for short. Such a theology has made it automatic for the replication of American churches on Philippine soil along with the attendant "Stateside" sectarian splits and doctrinal disputations. All these make this denomination a fitting illustration of Lapiz's claim that "Modern Christianity is a western franchise" (Lapiz 2005: 186).

In this context, by "western franchise" is meant that the American *CoC* serves as the model for the Philippine *CoC* in terms of missiological strategies, theological nomenclature, polemical themes and church polity, among others. Unlike in a regular franchise, however, "start up" funding comes largely from the franchisor and the franchisee's payment of "royalty" and other management fees come in the form of conversions, church planting and other tangible marks of

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a successful evangelistic enterprise. As this franchising system is seen as the only viable way of doing theology, the *CoC* functions as a religious guild which Pascal Boyer (2001: 275) defines as "a group that derives its livelihood, influence and power from the fact that it provides particular services, in particular the performance of rituals". As a guild, the *CoC* offers a particular brand (or in this group's parlance, "the marks of the One, True, Church"), reserving the exclusive right to authenticity, as articulated by one of its contemporary right-wing apologists:

> Churches of Christ have a unique plea in the religious world. . . . Our plea is to lay aside human creeds, sectarian names, and denominational divisions and to be one in Christ . . . let us go back to the Bible, all the way back beyond Constantinople and Rome, focusing instead upon Jerusalem in the first century, on the day of Pentecost when the Lord established *his* church. This is sometimes called the *restoration plea* – the plea to restore pure, simple, New Testament practice in the present age, so that we are members of the *same* church about which we read in the New Testament. (Highers 2009a: 3, emphasis his).

This article problematizes this claim by appropriating Michel Foucault's notion of discourse – i.e., a system of concepts, statements and practices that prescribes and proscribes thought, speech and behavior and which thus frames individual or group worldview (Foucault 1972). This critique, therefore, will focus not only on the textual but also on the extra-textual production of the *CoC*.

For Foucault, while discourse is totalizing and regulative, it nevertheless provides for its own subversion and overthrow:

> [Discourse] can be both an instrument and an effect of power, but also a hindrance, a stumbling block, a point of resistance and a starting point for an opposing strategy. Discourse transmits and produces power; it reinforces it, but also undermines it and exposes it, renders it fragile and makes it possible to thwart it. (Foucault 1978: 101).

In reference to *CoC* restorationism, attempts will be made to show how some of its own distinctive discourse can undermine its truth claims: how its very nature generates internal dissensions and ruptures, how its own exclusionary lexicon can spell its own state of alienation, and how its rigid and West-centric theological framework can become a form of cultural imperialism which renders it incompatible with and deleterious to but easily subverted by indigenous culture (i.e., that of the Igorots of Northern Philippines). It will be argued that there is no clearer demonstration of such theological imperiousness than the *CoC*'s adversarial stance against indigenous knowledge systems and practices and its neglect of local languages while promoting the language of colonization in its printed and oral materials.

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2 The Stone-Campbell Movement and American exceptionalism

The *American Restoration Movement (ARM)* – or more appropriately, the *Stone-Campbell Movement* (*SCM*), after its two most influential pioneers Barton Warren Stone and Alexander Campbell and in recognition of hundreds of other restorationist movements in Christendom (Garrett 1991: 59, 1994: 7) – is one of the religious trails that blazed the 19th century American frontier. Touted as "America's oldest ecumenical movement" (Shelburne 1968: 1), it gave the previously "inherently divisive" concept of restorationism (i.e. breaking away from an established church) a "new American twist" by employing it as a unifying tool, an explosive weapon to be deployed against the fortresses of denominationalism (Foster 1988a: 26). As one of its scholars succinctly puts it,

> Unity was the great goal. The method would be biblical primitivism; the means would be "restoring the ancient order of things." The "ancient order" would be rediscovered by using the Bible alone without addition of human creeds or denominational distinctive. Through this approach, the restorers argued, the church could return to "primitive Christianity"; it could reconstruct the pattern of the New Testament Church and restore pure, undenominational New Testament Christianity. (Dudrey 1988: 17–18)

This movement gave birth to the *Christian Church / Disciples of Christ (DoC)*, the *Independent Christian Church / Church of Christ (ICC)*, and the *Church/es of Christ* (*CoC*).

The history of the *SCM* reveals its strong link with "American Exceptionalism" which, according to Mark Slouka, is the idea that regards "America as an elect nation, the world-redeeming ark of Christ, chosen, above all the nations of the world, for a special dispensation" (in Baxter 2004: 56). Conceptually the same as the United States' political doctrine of "Manifest Destiny", American exceptionalism found expression during the formative years of the *SCM*. In his greatly influential journal, *The Millennial Harbinger*, Alexander Campbell wrote about the existence of

> . . . a scheme of things presented, in what is called the *Ancient Gospel,* which is long enough, broad enough, strong enough for the whole superstructure called the Millennial Church – and that it will alone be the *instrument* of *converting* the whole human race, and of *uniting* all Christians upon one and the same foundation. (Campbell 1830: 58, emphases his)

According to *CoC* historian Earl Irvin West, Campbell also believed that "missions could best be done by the establishment of Christian colonies where the Christian life, as well as Christian doctrine would serve as an instrument of

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evangelism" (West 1979: 315). His missiological and eschatological vision (which antedated the formal articulation of the Manifest Destiny doctrine in 1845) perhaps contributed to the assertion that the seminal period of Campbellian Restorationism was Manifest Destiny's "religious expression" (Dudrey 1988: 18).

The *SCM*, along with other American religious movements, made its presence felt in the Philippines in the early 20th century coinciding with the United States' colonial project in Asia. The *CoC* planted its first church in the southwestern Luzon island of Mindoro in the late 1920s (Benson 1974: 30–31; Wilkey 2000: 4–6), and made its formal missionary ventures in the Cordillera in 1952 with the establishment of the *Philippine Bible College* (PBC) in the City of Baguio (Tanicala 1997: 42). From the early 1960s to the late 1970s (Tanicala 1981: 2), membership fluctuated as follows: 8,000–10,000 (1961); 7,000–8,000 (1974); 6,000–7,000 (1977). Nearly two decades later, the number of congregations was placed at 200 (Tanicala 1997: 42) with probably over 10,000 members. In the early 2000s, this number increased to 400–500 with a generous estimate of 30,000 adherents (Cariaga and Belo 2001: 116). A few years later, a *CoC* directory (Cariaga 2005) lists 635 local churches with no estimate of membership.

As Gerald H. Anderson had well documented, "Manifest Destiny" was tied to the early Protestant missionary ventures in the Philippines (Anderson 1969: 279–300). A classic illustration of this was Episcopalian Bishop Charles Henry Brent's declaration:

> I am sent to the Philippines on the ancient principle that the cross must always follow the flag, and I feel I am not merely a representative of the church, but a representative of a citizenship. It has been impossible for me to make any line of demarcation between the Christian's responsibility and the citizen's responsibility. (Scott 1989: 56).

To his credit, Brent adopted "a policy of 'non-interference' " in relation to other Christian denominations and focused Episcopalian missions on Filipinos and non-Filipinos across the archipelago "who were not being served by any other church" including the ethnolinguistic groups of the Cordilleras (Chaokas 2009: 127).

The *CoC* today may not share Campbell's eschatological speculation and its American missionaries in the Philippines may not have engaged in overt imperialist rhetoric akin to Brent's; nevertheless, it carries over to a postcolonial world its own version of American exceptionalism through a patternistic hermeneutic (i.e., viewing the New Testament as a "blueprint" that spells out a rigid pattern for ecclesial doctrine and practice which must be restored and reproduced in our times, in America and elsewhere).

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While *CoC* preachers claim theological rootedness in what they have styled as pure New Testament Christianity just as the (Baptist) Fundamentalists in the Philippines do (Woods 2002: 3), it cannot be gainsaid that their three-pronged hermeneutic – (direct) command, (approved) example and necessary inference – was heavily influenced by Reformation theology, Scottish Common Sense Realism and Baconian-Lockian epistemology, and the spiritual sensibility of the American frontier, as amply demonstrated by *CoC* historians themselves (Dudrey 1988: 21–37; Allen et al. 1988: 25–36; Garrett 1994: 21–43; Childers et al. 2002: 65–89; Holloway and Foster 2006: 9–19; cf. Niehbuhr 1957: 178–81).

The *SCM*'s early ecumenism eventually calcified into a religious system beset by protracted and multipronged sectarian bickering. Reuel Lemmons, former editor of the conservative *CoC* journal *Firm Foundation,* candidly confessed:

> A movement which began on the glorious note of uniting the Christians in all the sects has degenerated in a mere century and a half, into subdividing that unity into narrow, sectarian camps. Each splinter splinters further. This very obvious fact is evidence that something is basically wrong in the attitude and aim of the movement. (in Garrett 1994: 17)

Garrett traces the major cause of this scandal to the problematic concept of "restoration" and proposed that "the real genius of the [SCM]" was its being "a unity movement and a reformation more than a restoration movement," adding that since "restoration . . . tends to be ahistorical" and "assumes a simplistic hermeneutics," it cannot adequately and correctly capture the ecumenical ideals of the Movement (Garrett 1994: 6–12). It may well be that the iconoclastic temper of the *SCM* founders (Foster 1988b: 6) is partly to be faulted: an ideological movement driven by iconoclasticism is bound to be undermined by its own iconoclasticism.

In the U.S., there has been a trend in recent decades among members of the *CoC* to return to the more irenic spirit of the founders of the SCM and an increasing diversity of beliefs and practices such that even hardliners have warned their faithful flocks of another "major rupture" (Sanders 2002: 29) reminiscent of the *DoC-CoC* schism formally made public in 1906 (cf. West 1979: 23–48). In the March 2002 issue of *The Christian chronicle*, "an international newspaper for churches of Christ", Bobby Ross, Jr. wrote of an "identity crisis" in the *CoC*, an observation shared by other *CoC* writers (Holloway and Foster 2006: 123–132; Foster 1994: 1–13; Highers 2009b: 47–48). On the other hand, the *CoC* in the Philippines have remained almost uniformly "conservative" – i.e., generally adhering to the doctrinal positions regularly articulated in right-wing *CoC* journals and magazines like *The voice of truth international*, *The spiritual sword*, *Truth for today* and *Gospel advocate* which are distributed to many *CoC* leaders in the Philippines.

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3 Western franchise

As earlier mentioned, Boyer uses the Medieval concept of guilds to explain the nature of religious exclusivism. A religious guild, he says, attempts to present itself as the only legitimate purveyor of truth by creating a "brand", a service package marked by its uniqueness, replicability, identifiability and exclusivity (Boyer 2001: 277). In the *CoC*'s patternistic discourse, the distinctive "Marks of the True Church" are clear and reproducible anywhere, anytime. See Figure 1.

Filipino theologian Timoteo Gener has pointed out the tendency of some Christian denominations to copy "foreign theological packages" and present these as "irrefutable, biblical universals" unsaddled by "cultural baggage" (Gener 2005: 5). His observation applies to the *CoC* in the Philippines for their ecclesial traits mirror those of their traditional American counterparts.

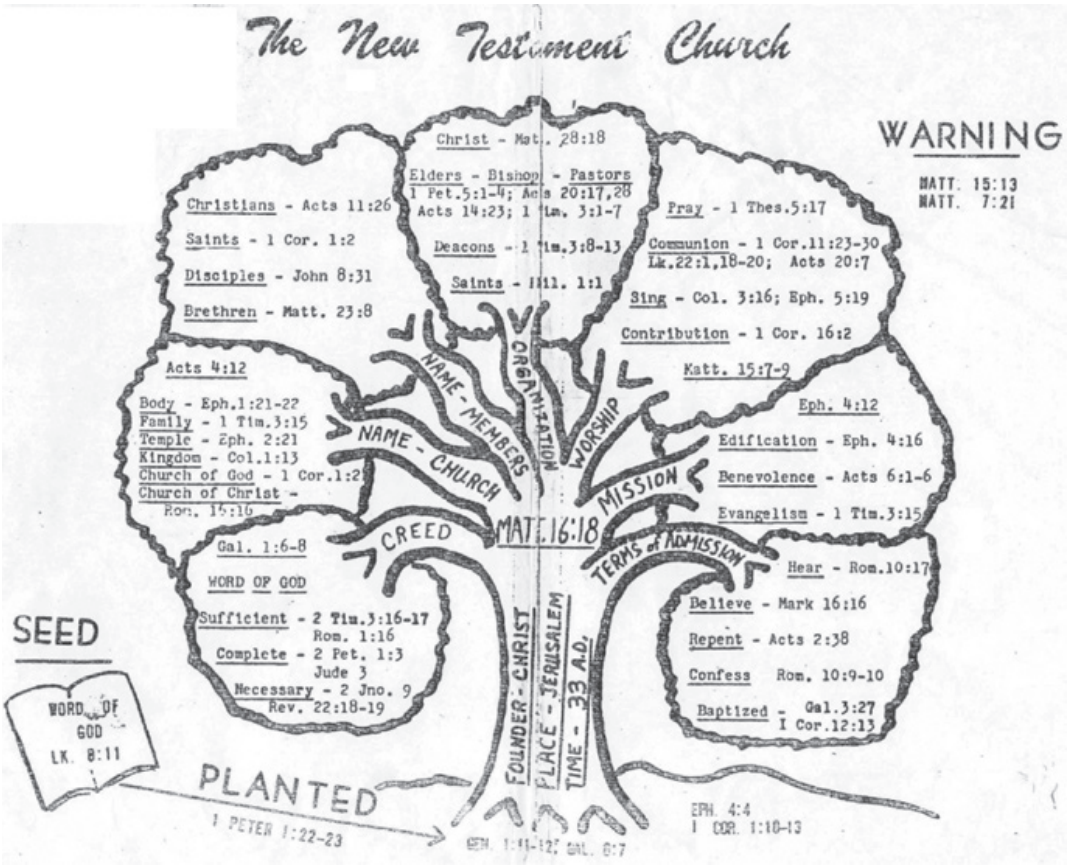


Fig. 1: The *CoC* Guild. As a religious guild, the *CoC* offers to a lost world the only way to salvation – becoming a member of the one true church which, with its unmistakable identifying marks, can be replicated anywhere, anytime.

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The Philippine *CoC* operate over a dozen small preacher training schools and two Christian colleges most of which are largely financed by *CoC* individuals and groups in the U.S. A good number of local ministers are paid by their own congregations, but many others continue to receive partial or full monetary support from abroad. Even para-church organizations and projects like the *Medical Action for Relief, Counseling and Healing (MARCH) for Christ* are heavily funded by U.S.-based churches. It may be suspected that this continuing financial dependence on foreign support has helped ensure that curricular preferences and proselyting strategies are approximately patterned after those of the benefactors.

The dollar subsidy has meant the exportation of doctrinal issues and institutional splits to the Philippines from America. Pedantic disputations so characteristic of many *CoC* in the U.S.A. and largely irrelevant to the existential concerns of the Filipino have been passed on to Philippine churches and have caused many *CoC* congregations to be alienated from the rest of the communities. As in America, *CoC* groups and individuals in the Cordillera and across the country place themselves or are identified as theologically right-wing or left-wing depending on certain practices involving the number of cups to be used in the Communion, use or non-use of instruments of music in church activities, use of church funds, the putting up of Bible schools and other programs viewed by some as "shades of Institutionalism", among other issues. Oftentimes, the missiological targets of the *CoC* in the Philippines become arenas where white (*CoC*) men promoting a doctrinal hobby attempt to save brown men from the pernicious doctrines of other white (*CoC*) men, to paraphrase Gayatri Spivak (1988: 297). This, in turn, has led to the counterproductive competition among some Filipino preachers for higher financial support from their White brothers. On this problem Robert Buchanan (2001: 107), American missionary to the Philippines for over three decades, says in his overview of *CoC* missions in the country: "False teaching, financed by overseas sources, has divided congregations. The challenges involved in overseas financing had to be confronted." What he calls as "false teaching" is, of course, what other *CoC* missionaries would style as "pure gospel".

Following their American brothers, Philippine *CoC* also observe "local/congregational autonomy" and strongly oppose the establishment of any permanent para-church or centralized ecclesial structures. Despite its ideological attraction, this democratizing arrangement has meant sacrificing organizational efficiency to uphold a doctrine of polity; a religious body scattered over 600 congregations with a congregational membership average of 30, without considerable material resources generally and with no central (regional and/or national) organization, can hardly effect a grand missiological plan for an archipelago of over 90 million people.

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Worship format among Philippine *CoC* has, to a large extent, remained unchanged for decades and faithful to the "five avenues of worship" tradition of American *CoC*: choir-less a capella singing; five prayers – one opening, one closing, one for the Communion bread, another for the fruit of the vine (not "wine"), and another for the collection ("giving"); and a sermon (approximately at the middle of the "worship service" and preferably peppered with "book, chapter and verse"). All these activities are led or administered by men.

Religious franchising is not only evident in the *CoC*'s rituals, polity, projects, divisions and funding sources but also in their discursive (language-based) materials and polemical engagements. In narrativizing church history, for instance, Filipino *CoC* preachers simply retell the American version, as shown in Figure 2 and Figure 3.

Note that despite the addition of other Philippine churches in Figure 1, the two charts are practically the same in their privileging of their restorationist version of the historical development of Christianity as outlined in F. W. Mattox's *The eternal kingdom* (1961). Although some Filipino preachers (Tanicala 2009) have come to reject the simplistic "The Church, the Falling Away, and the Restoration" narrative (Shepherd 1973) which presents genuine Christianity as practically nonexistent – or at least the silent minority – during the Middle Ages and the

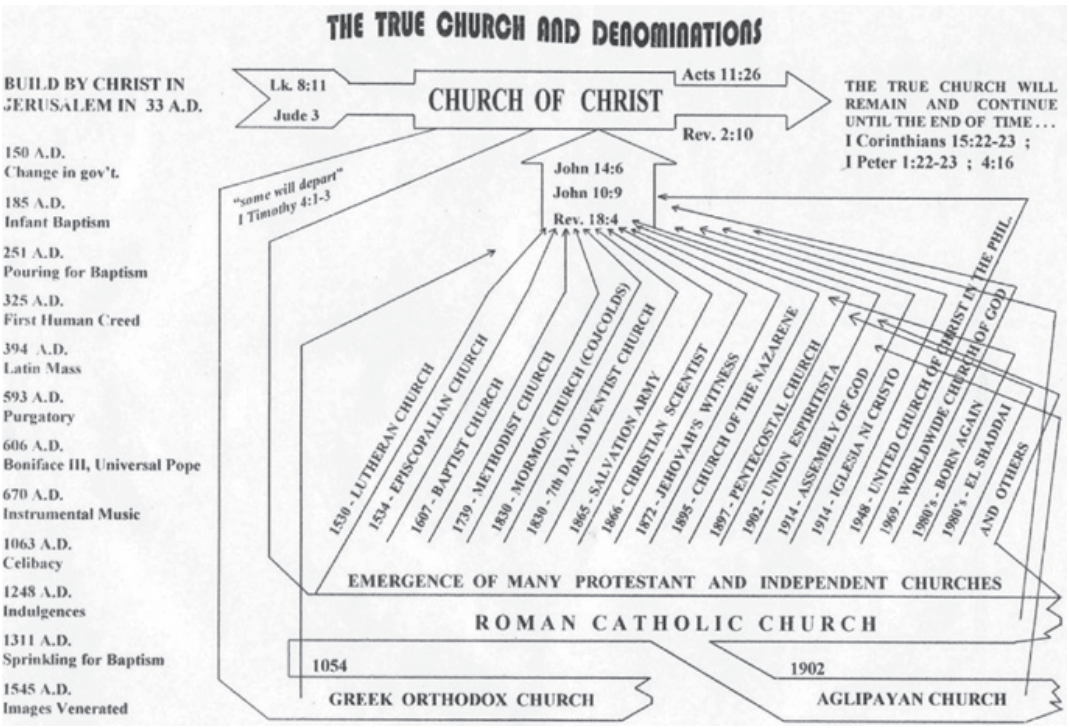


Fig. 2: Church history chart, prepared by Emilio D. Panday (Baguio City, Philippines)

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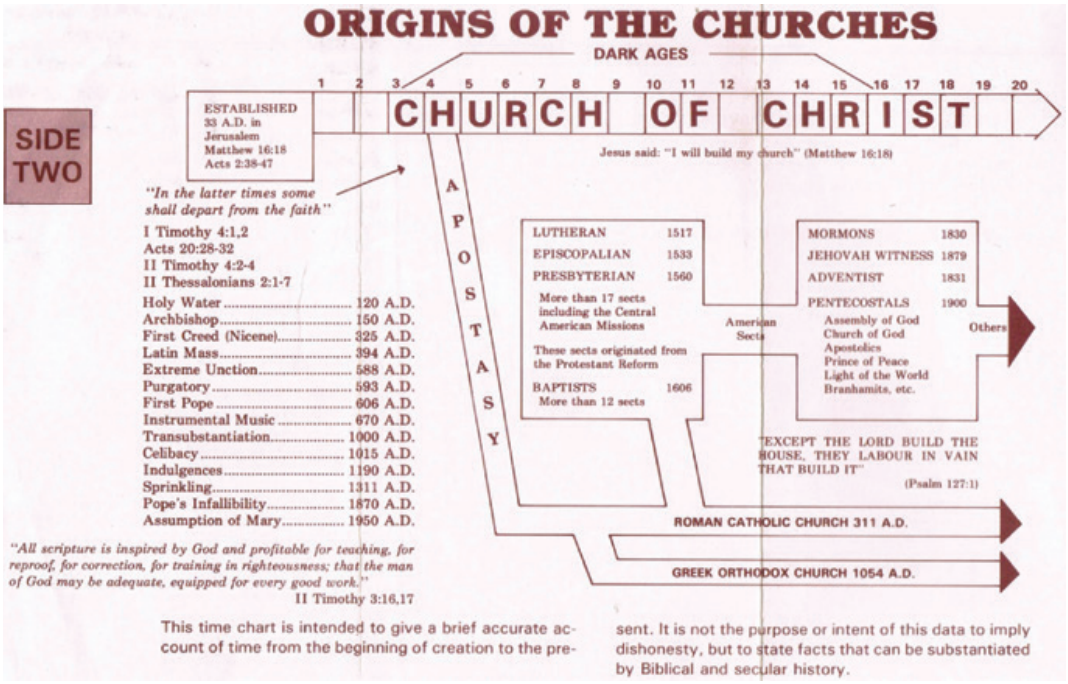


Fig. 3: Church history chart, prepared by Dryden Sinclair (1980)

Reformation only to be restored in America in the 19th century, they nevertheless maintain that their church was "established in 33 A.D." and that all the denominations originated after the first century and therefore cannot be "the Lord's Church".

In the style of their American brethren, Filipino *CoC* preachers routinely assert the "undenominational" nature of their church, some of them consciously writing "church of Christ" even when the term is used as a proper noun or in reference to a local congregation – a practice which one of their lamented scholars, Grover C. Brewer, dismissed as "laughable" for being "unscriptural and ungrammatical" (in Foster 1994: 46). This claim to being undenominational has naturally puzzled other Christian bodies who note that *Church of Christ* has been extensively and exclusively used as the official appellation in this restorationist group's signages, sermons and publications (see Figures 4–7).

This "denominational" use of church name has not escaped the critique of some Filipino *CoC* preachers like Vincent Ragay (1991: 7) who fault their brethren's tendency to condemn their own for using a church name other than "Church of Christ". This predilection to excoriate those who change church billboard signs is, of course, borrowed from the America where, for instance, the celebrated author-preacher (and now *CoC* defector) Max Lucado was condemned by *CoC* hardliners for changing his congregation's name from "Oak Hills Church

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Fig. 4: Appellative fad. Uncapitalizing the first "c" in "Church of Christ", another imported fad, has become fashionable for some *CoC* congregations in the Philippines. *Berryville Bible Beacon* is the news bulletin of a *CoC* congregation in Arkansas.

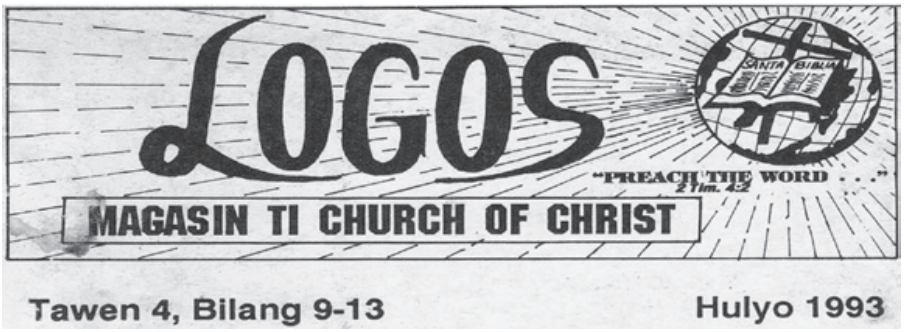


Fig. 5: A franchised name. The use of *Church of Christ* instead of the vernacular *Iglesia Ni Cristo* shows how the name has become the official, exclusive name of this group. Practically, it distinguishes itself from the formidable homegrown sect, the *Iglesia Ni Cristo* founded by Felix Manalo in 1914.

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The Christian Chronicle®

Vol. 62 No. 1 An international newspaper for members of churches of Christ January 2005

Iraq reservists need churches to 'share sacrifices'

CHURCH MEMBERS IN THE RESERVES or National Guard have traded being 'weekend warriors' for active duty in Iraq. Churches must provide these families spiritual – and practical – support, leaders say.

BY LINDY ADAMS

Tom Learned e-mails his family faithfully from his position 45 miles north of Baghdad.

SEE THE CHRONICLE ONLINE: www.christianchronicle.org

INSIDE

Keepsakes from Latin America

Fig. 6: American *CoC* newspaper. *The Christian Chronicle* is a popular Oklahoma-based newspaper that seeks "to inform, inspire, and unite Churches of Christ worldwide".


PHILIPPINE CHRISTIAN CHRONICLE

NATIONAL NEWSPAPER FOR THE MEMBERS OF CHURCHES OF CHRIST IN THE PHILIPPINES

VOL. NO. 4 ISSUE NO. 14 OCTOBER 2001

4000 TREATED IN KALINGA

"M.A.R.C.H and M.O.S.E.S. Together in One Purpose For Evangelism"

The **M.A.R.C.H.** (Medical Assistance for Relief, Counseling, and Healing) for Christ once again held a very successful 3 Days Medical Mission in **Tabuk, Kalinga, Luzon, on October 24-26, 2001**. Together with the **M.O.S.E.S.** Team, they made another attainment in the history of Philippine Medical Missions.

The chartered bus, with all the participants arrived at **Kalinga Hotel** on October 23 together with the other

KALINGA HOSTEL

Around the PHILIPPINES

BULACAN

The church in Malolos, Bulacan has just moved to another location. The address is # 453 Hipolito St., Caingin, Malolos, Bulacan. *(Daniel Enriquez)*

COTABATO CITY

Fig. 7: Appellative franchising in nameplates. The nameplate of this local newspaper illustrates the nature of religious franchising (cf. Fig. 6). Note that *MARCH* and *MOSES* are both parachurch organizations/programs which some *CoC* preachers have branded as marks of liberalism/denominationalism.

of Christ" to "Oak Hills Church" and supposedly marking his "departure from the old paths" in the process (McDade 2004: 4).

It has also been noted by critics of the *CoC* that while it professes to have "No Creed But Christ", it has churned out religious materials containing statements of faith (creed) – like Guy Caskey's pamphlet, "What is the Church of Christ",

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Jule Miller's *Visualized Bible Study Series* (VBSS) or the *World Bible School* (WBS) lessons – which ensure relative uniformity of faith and practice. Further while the *CoC* has no central organization, it has local and national organizations, programs and publications among which are the *Asia/n Mission Forum*, *M.A.R.C.H. for Christ*, *National Evangelism Workshop Seminar* (NEWS), regional *Panagkakadua* (Fellowship) in northern Luzon, *Philippine Bible College Alumni Association* (PBCAA), *Word Ministry Baguio*, *Philippine Christian Chronicle*, *Let's Start Talking (LST)*, *Truth for the World (TFT)*, *WBS* and *World English Institute (WEI)*. Indeed, as the promotion of all these necessarily involve intercongregational cooperation, the *CoC* virtually act and are identified as one denomination. For as *CoC* author Samuel Dawson (2006: 15) argued, "*a coalition of churches acting together*" is acting denominationally (emphasis his). *CoC* "Prince of Preachers" Nicholas Brodie Hardeman thus missed the point when he argued that the *CoC* is not a denomination because a denomination "is a religious organization larger than the local church [and] smaller than the redeemed in the aggregate" (in Winkler 2001: 36). A denominational status is not simply determined by the existence of relatively fixed parachurch structures; it basically lies in pan-congregational work and identification.

While Dawson entertains the possibility of the *CoC* reclaiming a non-denominational status, *Brethren* scholar Alex Koivisto offers no such hope for restorationist churches. He explains that

> . . . any group of related churches which find part of their reason for being a unity in the *opposition* to denominationalism have already *defined* themselves denominationally. An undenominational group has never survived, by definition, as a "non-denomination . . ."
>
> One cannot, by definition, oppose denominationalism without becoming one. Those who are attracted to an anti-denominational status ultimately unite in their opposition. This requires mutual support and relationship, the earmarks of denominational relations. (Koivisto 1993: 96–97, emphasis his)

The problem, he argues, is not denominationalism but sectarianism which he defines as the narrowing down of the ground of acceptable Christian fellowship and cooperation due to a broadening of what is considered orthodox doctrine.

> It is therefore my (or my group's) refusing to allow for diversity in others and demanding conformity with all my views, as if my view (in full detail) alone had divine sanction. It is the notion that I, or my own specific group alone has a market on the truth, to the exclusion of others. (Koivisto 1993: 44–45)

Borrowing from Freud, Avishai Margalit (2008: 39) refers to this sectarian mindset as "the narcissism of small differences": what the rest of the world sees as

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minor differences are to the sectarian of utmost importance. Thus, sectarians tend

> [T]o inflate a minor disagreement over beliefs or practices into the impossibility of living together. The sectarian behaves like a social amoeba: even when there is only one cell it manages to split. In an adverse environment the sectarian-like amoeba tends to become a cyst, closing itself totally to the outside world in order to stay alive. (Avishai Margalit 2008: 39)

Certainly, the *CoC*'s sectarianism is its own undoing. Its lexicon of classification and exclusion has generated for itself more disputes and divisions than it can handle, and an unsavory reputation in many communities in the Philippines. "Sound preachers", "faithful brethren", "false teachers", "apostates", "denominational practices", "liberals", "conservatives", etc. have specialized meanings among and are regularly used by Filipino *CoC* preachers and members in their "othering" practices among themselves and in their interaction with their religious neighbors. Misguided Filipino preachers often imitate the up-front speech of their White brothers in their rhetoric, oblivious to the fact that, as S. I. and Alan Hayakawa put it, " 'telling it like it is' " often "provide[s] our minds with a greased runway down which we may slide back into unexamined and reactive patterns of evaluation and behavior" (Hayakawa and Hayakawa 2000: 260).

As noted earlier, one's place in the Philippine *CoC* Liberal-Conservative theological spectrum is determined by the subject position of speakers on imported issues. Among many in the so-called "Mainstream" churches, to be conservative not only means adhering to doctrines universally acknowledged as "orthodox" (e.g. the Trinity, Virgin Birth, Mosaical authorship of the Pentateuch), but also not using instruments of music or not dancing/clapping in worship, not having choirs in the assembly, not allowing women to take leadership roles in church, not fellowshipping with "the denominations" (some *CoC* groups included), not denying the essentiality of immersion in the scheme of redemption, not eating *dinuguan* (native delicacy cooked in animal blood), not participating in *cañao* (indigenous/Igorot community feast), not officially participating in mass actions involving socio-political issues in the community, not believing in the miraculous endowment or "personal indwelling of the Holy Spirit", and not teaching Premillenialism/Dispensationalism, among others.

4 Silencing the indigenous

CoC Restorationism's homogenizing missiology, sectarian rhetoric and intramural discord have contributed to the continuing fragmentation of a nation

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spread over 7,000 islands and speaking 170 languages. In its eccleciocentrism, it has failed to grasp issues of identity among Indigenous Peoples, especially the Igorots – the historico-political constructedness of their pan-Cordilleran identity, the practical relational issues arising from their multiethnicity, and their need to transcend tribalism and to strengthen interethnic dialogues. This is especially true in Kalinga, home to at least 44 "subtribes" (Balbin and Garming 2003: 6–11), a few of which have been involved in sporadic clannish conflicts.

As far as this author can verify, none of the *CoC*'s foreign and local missionaries have conducted or showed significant interest in ethnographic studies on the Cordillera, and most tended to be dismissive of the "pagan" culture of the Igorots. It is no surprise then that the curriculum of the *Philippine Bible College* in Baguio City – the Cordillera's tourist, religious, educational and political hub – has no clearly defined courses on contemporary issues in Missiology in the context of Cordilleran culture (see Figures 8 and Figure 9).

Meanwhile, Catholic, Anglican and most Pentecostal and Evangelical groups in the Cordillera have long made serious efforts at indigenizing their theology with their incorporation of native musical instruments and melodies into their liturgies and use of the elements of local culture to explain Christian concepts. They have also contributed to the socio-cultural and political development of the Igorots by putting up museums, schools and livelihood projects; documenting indigenous knowledge, systems and practices; helping eradicate counterproductive traditional practices like head-taking; and actively engaging in community

AREAS OF CONFLICT	*CoC* RESTORATIONISM	PHILIPPINE INDIGENOUS RELIGION
View of Community	Homogenizing, sectarian language & practice	Issues of multiethnicity, interethnicity, and ethnocentricity
Approach to Piety	Rational, compartmentalized	Affective-intuitive over rational sense, holistic
Gender Roles	Androcentric, subordinated role for women	Active leadership roles for women

Fig. 8: The CoC brand of restorationism has failed to make an effective dialogue with its culture.

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FIRST YEAR (First Semester)

1. 111 Genesis
2. 112 Matthew
3. 113 Christian Doctrine
4. 114 Bible Geography
5. 115 Music I
6. 116 Speech
7. 117 English I

FIRST YEAR (Second Semester)

1. 121 Exodus– Deuteronomy
2. 122 mark and Luke
3. 123 Christian Doctrine II
4. 124 Christian Home
5. 125 Music II
6. 126 Principles of Teaching
7. 127 English II

SECOND YEAR (First Semester)

1. 211 John
2. 212 O.T. Historical Books
3. 213 Church Management
4. 214 Personal Evangelism
5. 215 Teaching Children (Women)
6. 216 Homiletics (Men)
7. 217 Church in the Bible
8. 218 General Biblical Introduction

SECOND YEAR (Second Semester)

1. 221 Acts of the Apostles
2. 222 O.T. Poetical Books
3. 223 Preacher's Life and Works
4. 224 Personal Evangelism II
5. 225 Chorus (Music)
6. 226 Homiletics II
7. 227 Church History I

THIRD YEAR (First Semester)

1. 311 Romans
2. 312 Isaiah
3. 313 Christian Evidence
4. 314 Prison Epistles
5. 315 Greek
6. 316 Homiletics III
7. 317 Church History II

THIRD YEAR (Second Semester)

1. 321 Galatians and Hebrews
2. 322 Daniel - Malachi
3. 323 Argumentations and Debate
4. 324 Pastoral Epistles
5. 325 Greek II
6. 326 Revelations
7. 327 Denominations and Errors

FOURTH YEAR(First Semester)

1. 411 Spl. And Gen. Epistles
2. 412 Jeremiah and Ezekiel 413 Hermeneutics
3. 414 Archaeology
4. 415 Hebrew I
5. 416 Guidance and Counseling
6. 417 Preaching and Print Media

FOURTH YEAR (second semester)
421 Corinthians Epistles

1. 423 Non– Christian Religion
2. 424 Current Church issues
3. 425 Hebrew II
4. 426 Jewish History
5. 427 Preaching and broadcast Media

Fig. 9: Philippine Bible College (PBC), Baguio City BTh Curriculum SY 2010–2011

issues (Chaokas 2009: 126–143; cf. Centeno and Peralta 2011). In the field of linguistics, many of these denominations have immensely contributed to the preservation and enrichment of Cordilleran languages through Bible translations, local dictionaries, grammar manuals and worship songs in various Igorot languages. The *CoC* in the Cordilleras, in contrast, has a dismal record on this score. For while it has used Ilocano – considered as the lingua franca of most of northern Philippines – along with English in its evangelistic and edification materials and activities, its scholars and preachers have virtually failed to promote the languages of the Bontok, Ibaloi, Ifugao, Kalinga, Kankanaey, Ibaloi, Isneg and Itneg. As far as I can determine, the *CoC* has never made any scholarly study on any of the Igorot languages. Hymnals, tracts and other religious materials the *CoC* have distributed in the Cordillera are mostly in English, Ilocano or Tagalog. Even sermons and "Bible Studies" are mostly done in these three languages. One ex-

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planation could be that only a few of the *CoC*'s preachers are Igorots and only a few Igorots are converted to the *CoC*. This failure to convert the natives in droves may be illustrative of the church's failure to connect with its host culture whose languages it has silenced in its evangelistic discourse. Yet another explanation could be that its imperialistic theological framework has rendered it blind to the value of the Igorots' local language and language ecology, and thus to the importance of local language and indigenized theology.

As most *CoC* preachers in the Cordillera take an antagonistic approach to indigenous culture, they do not make a decent effort at understanding it and are quickly dismissive of Igorot rituals like the *cañao* as vestiges of paganism. Without such an adopted orientalist outlook, they would have observed as Maggay did, that

> A core theme in Filipino culture is our sense of connectedness, of being part of an intricate network of relationships. The metaphor used to describe this is the "multiple fried eggs." If you fry many eggs in one large pan, thee whites are seamlessly connected to each other. While there are individual yolks, you don't know where one egg ends and the next begins. This mirrors the Filipino sense of self, always connected, always part of a larger *sakop*. . . .
>
> Many upland community festivals are meant for ancestral heroes, like *Kabigat* and *Balitok* among the Ikalahan. In these communities, the *cañao* is a sign and seal of the people's sense of identity together as a community. (Maggay 2005: 47)

Aside from introducing divisive theological issues into indigenous communities, the *CoC* has also failed to explore the rich cultural themes among the Igorots like the Kalinga concepts of *matagoan* (zone of life and peace), *bodong* (peace pact) or *pagta* (peace pact code) and mainstream these into their theology. Thus, to many Igorots the *CoC* Gospel remains largely what Filipino theologian Rene C. Padilla calls "a *logos asarkos* (an unincarnate word), a message that [can only touch] lives only tangentially" (Teague 1996: 456).

5 Cerebral piety

West (1994: 92), in his backgrounder on the *SCM*'s "The instrumental music controversy" of 1866–1870, commented: "The introduction of a musical instrument into a church is a triumph of the sensual over the spiritual". This demonization of instrumental music, drawn from Campbell's rationalistic approach to Bibliology and Ecclesiology, is a regular fare among *CoC* writers (Highers 2004: 2–24; Hadwin 1998: 54–67; Sameon 2005: 36–39).

This doctrine has not gone unchallenged by other *CoC* writers who share Danny Corbit's view that in its dogmatic insistence on the "unscripturality" of

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instrumental music in Christian worship, the *CoC* has "missed more than music" (Corbit 2008). Interestingly, the late Ralph Brashears, a chaplain in General Douglas MacArthur's landing forces in Lingayen, Pangasinan and founder of the *Philippine Bible College (PBC)*, had repudiated this doctrine in his commentary on *Revelation* (Brashears 1989: 268, 291, 458–459). Also, it is widely known that the 10,000-strong *Richland Hills Church of Christ*, said to be the largest *CoC* congregation in the world, broke tradition in 2009 by adding musical instruments to its corporate worship.

In their practice of this doctrine, many Filipino *CoC* members find themselves conflicted or inconsistent when faced with questions on listening to recorded Christian hymns accompanied by musical instruments and having pianos, guitars, etc. in their homes. In resolving the question, rationalization is made in at least two ways: (1) distinguishing private activities from public worship – i.e., what is disallowed is the use of musical instruments during corporate worship and that privately listening to Christian music or playing piano while singing gospel songs at home is not worship or does not violate Biblical principles; or (2) dichotomizing the sacred from the profane – i.e., it is all right to listen to songs with instrumental background or to play musical instruments so long as these do not involve gospel hymns. One can thus listen to *Metallica* and other rock music in private while condemning the use of instruments of music in gospel singing.

This compartmentalized view of spirituality is a Western construct. Traditionally, Filipinos "do not distinguish between public and private" and "have no indigenous word for privacy and do not know the concept" (Maggay in Suk 2005: 43; see Pertierra 1995: 98–99). The sacred-profane binarism is also problematic among indigenous cultures which view their existence holistically. Kalinga scholar Esteban Magannon's observation on the Lubo subtribe in Kalinga generally holds true to other ethnolinguistic groups in the Cordillera:

> Religion among them . . . embraces the totality of life. Life . . . in essence is religion. . . .
>
> It transcends in its simplicity the distinction between the sacred and the profane so that every human activity whether big or small is equally religious since they all contribute to make life and existence *malinawa* (peaceful). The profound consequence of this is that the individual experiences life and existence as a continuous integrated unity and it is precisely anything which breaks this continuous unity that demoralizes and destroys man and renders human life and existence absurd and meaningless because they become disparate and dissolve into chaotic pieces with the intrusion of conflicts and fragmentations. (Magannon 1972: 48, 60–61).

Attendant to this anti-instruments doctrine is the imported contention that humming during communion, handclapping, raising of hands, dancing, exclaiming "Amen!" in response to a sermon, choirs or praise teams and dramatic perfor-

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mances are "not scriptural" or are "unauthorized by God" (Miller 1996: 204–224). While this dogma is being challenged and discarded by an increasing number of *CoC* people in the United States, the *CoC* in the Philippines generally maintain their traditional stance on the matter. This cerebral approach to worship naturally clashes with Filipino culture, in which "the affective-intuitive sense (*pagdama*) of an event is more critical than merely the *isip*, or rational sense" (Gener 2005: 6). The dogma does epistemic violence to indigenous culture steeped in music and dance. This author is witness to how Kalingas have forsaken their *gangsa* (gongs) or other indigenous and foreign instruments of music and the *tadjok* (native dance) as they became subjected to this rigid restorationist discourse. One wonders how this violence would affect other cultures like that of the Chinese whose parks regularly showcase their rich cultural heritage made more lively by their *erhu* (two-stringed fiddle) and *pipa* (lute) or *mángtǒng* (reed pipe). Or the African-American culture, knowing that Black music is characterized by the creative use of instruments and body movements as described by Daryl Cumber Dance:

> While talented musicians can make pianos moan, drums talk, and saxophones wail, they can also make music with spoons, pans, and a variety of improvised instruments. And then the body can always be called into play to provide a beat – foot stomping and tapping, hand clapping, body slapping, and varied uses of the mouth can suffice when there are no drums or pans or extraneous sources around. (Dance 2002: 76)

Incidentally, the September 2008 online exclusive issue of *The Christian Chronicle* ran Bobby Ross, Jr.'s article, "Leaders tackle questions on race and the Church" (www.christianchronicle.org/article/leaders-tackle-questions-on-race-and-the-church, accessed 3 July 2010), in which Mike Root, an interviewee and preacher to a *CoC* congregation in Missouri, said:

> In my 35 years of ministry, I've seen a few Christians who decided on what church to attend, or not attend, based on prejudice, but most have picked from preference. In churches I've preached at in the past, I've had black members who purposely left and went back to black congregations because we were too stilted and undemonstrative in our assemblies. One sister in Virginia, while not changing her membership, had to visit her former black congregation to, as she said, "Get her fix." We teased and laughed with her a lot about her "need" and our "spiritless" traditions.

Root added that "even with all the efforts to remove racial barriers and promote racial equality, people still prefer their own cultural traditions".

In the case of the *CoC* in the Cordilleras, the imposition of a cerebral spirituality on the Igorots who strongly value their traditions has created barriers for the

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promotion of cross-cultural understanding and contextualized theology. It is thus common among Igorot communities where the *CoC* is located to regard *CoC* worship as "spiritless".

6 Women's roles

Asian Public Intellectual and Missionary Benedictine sister Mary John Mananzan (2004: 35) writes of the need for the "deconstruction of the dehumanizing aspects of institutional Christianity and reconstruction and enhancement of its more liberating elements" geared towards helping women "arrive at their full humanity". This is the challenge that must be hurled against androcentric western religious discourses.

In the *CoC*'s politics of ecclesial space, the woman's place is greatly limited. While it is true that *CoC* women hold "Ladies' Retreat" and other all-female activities at the local and national levels, they are relegated to menial tasks during "fellowships" where men and women are present. While women are also allowed to teach "Bible classes" for children, they may not teach "Bible subjects" in preacher training schools. In a Sunday assembly, women are barred from pulpit preaching, communion serving, and other "leadership roles" (Music 1991: 515–539; Miller 1996: 245–256). Among many *CoC* in the Philippines, this proscription extends to church business meetings which are virtually the men's arena of disputations. Under this system, it can happen that a congregation where women are learned and articulate often endure the speech of an untrained and inarticulate would-be preacher; or that an all-female church always has to await the arrival of a visiting male preacher to be able to "do worship".

Unfortunately, most women in the *CoC* are oblivious to the fact that the interpretation of Scripture regarding their subjection to men in church is determined by a particular theological school of thought and socio-cultural experience, and not necessarily by divine mandate as they have been made to believe. In *I permit not a woman . . . to remain shackled*, noted *CoC* elder and missionary Robert Rowland (1991) puts to task *CoC* hermeneuts for their fallacies and inconsistencies in their traditional stance on the woman's role in church. He observes:

> A doctrine on women has been built on three short passages in I Corinthians 11 and 14 and I Timothy 2. From this doctrine, a variety of traditions have been established. Then, using varying traditions as scriptural mandates, the leaders of the churches have developed a smorgasbord of practices which attempt to explain away other clear Bible teachings and Bible history. At the same time, both logic and consistency have been skewed and warped to accommodate the misinterpretation of scripture and to attempt to be consistent on flawed Biblical understanding. (Rowland 1991: 12)

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Just as the *CoC* has maimed or refused to optimize the musical potentials of its members, so has it chosen "[t]o overlook the evangelistic power of sixty percent of church membership, to bury their talents, and to not use their skills and strengths" (Rowland 1991: 22). It goes without saying, of course, that the *CoC*'s more perceptive religious neighbors both in the United States and the Philippines have not been slow to see through these fallacies and inconsistencies.

This devalorization of women in religion runs counter to the practices of the Bontok and Kalinga Igorots. In Bontoc communities, women are the primary bearers of rituals like the *manerwap* (rain-calling ceremony) or *sangachil* (death chair; traditional funeral rite). Among Kalingas, women have traditionally performed various ritual forms and "are called by diverse names according to the rituals they perform" (Magannon 1972: 49). Other Christian churches in the Cordillera, aware that the assumed Scriptures-culture clash on the matter is simply rooted in hermeneutical bias and although still needing systemic changes in their respective organizational structures, have not missed out on this aspect of indigenous culture and have continued to empower their women for leadership roles in their congregational activities and community work.

With its isolationism and sectarianism and in silencing women, the native and the native's existential concerns in its restorationist discourse, the *CoC*, in turn, has been relatively silenced in the collective Igorot consciousness. It has been largely unknown or unpopular among the natives with its less than 2,000 members distributed in around 40 mostly small congregations comprising only about one percent of the 1.5 million inhabitants of the Cordillera. Its small number of membership is a testament to the native culture's resistance to its rigid theological system that has shown no genuine sensitivity to what Lapiz terms as "cultural redemption", which Gener (2005: 18) broadened to include not only "redeeming Philippine music and dance" but all other "cultural activities" of Filipinos.

Speaking of the *ARM/SCM* missions, another long-time American *CoC* missionary in the Philippines once claimed: "Objective facts today reveal that George Pepperdine and George Benson, with some kind assistance from Leslie Wolfe, started a movement that is an undeniable success in Asia" (Wilkey 2001: 103). Knowing the internal divisions in the *CoC* and the ruptures its proselyting activities have caused on Christian communities in Asia, one finds it difficult to affirm this rosy view of the *SCM*. Further, any statistical reference on Christian adherents in Asia will reveal that the *SCM* has lagged far behind the missiological records of other Christian movements. And, if Anne C. Kwantes' *Chapters in Philippine church history* (2001: 191) is indicative of the various churches' impact on Philippine society, then the *CoC* has fared poorly, it being relegated to a footnote containing information primarily on the *DoC* and another *CoC* "cousin", the *United*

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Church of Christ. Also, despite over half a century of its existence in the City of Baguio, the *CoC* has failed to distinguish itself as a significant contributor to the development of this former U.S. colonial hill station. Proof of this is that during the city's centennial celebration in 2009, the *CoC* was not among the 100 institutions honored as "Builders of Baguio". The list includes the *Catholic Churches of Baguio*, the *Protestant Churches of Baguio*, the *United Church of Christ in the Philippines* and the *Iglesia Ni Cristo*.

The *CoC* is obviously "very much a minority religion in the Philippines in comparison to the many religious groups" in the Philippines, as one of its nationally known preachers affirmed (Belo 2001: 106). It may be added that such status is true in Asia and other parts of the world. On this fact, the late J. C. Choate, editor to the *Voice of truth*, admonished his brethren thusly:

> Christ made an important observation about majorities and minorities when He said, "Enter in at the strait gate: for wide is the gate, and broad is the way, that leadeth to destruction, and many there be which go thereat: Because strait is the gate, and narrow is the way, that leadeth to life, and few there be that find it" (Matthew 7:13,14). Based on this statement, if the Lord's church was the largest group of believes in Christ in the world today, I would have to question whether it was really the true church or not.
>
> Don't be ashamed of being with the minority, spiritually. Don't reject the Lord's church because it is small in comparison to other churches. Look at its teaching. Investigate it. Put the truth and the strait way above the physical and material things of the world. Remember, too, that when we are with God, we may seem in the minority numerically, but spiritually we are in the majority after all. (Choate 2000: 5)

Interestingly, Choate expresses exactly how sectarians intellectualize their smallness, as explained by Margalit:

> Sects are usually small, their ambitions big, if not downright megalomaniac. They want nothing short of salvation of the world. How do sects account for the gap between the smallness of their numbers and the immensity of their ambitions?
>
> One way of dealing with the gap is by denying the importance of numbers. Numbers don't count. There is no safety in numbers. . . . (Margalit 2008: 39)

It is a welcome thing that the *CoC* in the U.S., as exemplified in the work of van Rheenen and Waldron (2002), have recently shown greater efforts to keep abreast with the developments in Missiology pioneered by their religious neighbors. It is also worth noting that in the last two decades, the *CoC* in the Philippines has embarked on medical-dental missions and a few other civic projects and its local leadership has also increasingly taken ownership over various evangelistic works. As Buchanan observed:

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> More leadership work is being done, and more churches are becoming self-sufficient. Much of the evangelism and leadership training is being organized and accomplished by Filipino brothers, and the American preachers are often considered only as "helpers" or "co-workers", especially those who try to learn language and culture. Training seminars or forums have been organized and conducted, with vision and planning, by national leadership. Bible schools in different parts of the nation were begun, and continue to operate, with national direction and instruction. (Buchanan 2001: 107)

It remains to be seen though whether such developments will redound to the broadening of the sectarian outlook among its people, a truly contextualized theology and a more positive impact on local communities where a *CoC* is found.

7 Conclusion

William Henry Scott, the iconic American *Episcopal/Anglican Church* scholar and champion of Filipino indigenous rights, used the metaphor of what he called as "The Star-Spangled Curtain" to account for the historical amnesia afflicting Filipinos regarding the negative impact of the American colonial experience on their consciousness. On this curtain, he says, are emblazoned "not only nice stars to look at, but [also] slogans . . . mottos . . . good-sounding words and expressions", like "religious freedom", "self-government" and "independence", which have been popularized across the globe through textbooks and other media to promote a benevolent image of America (Scott: 1986).

This article is also about an attempt to help lift what I call as "The Star-Spangled Banner of the Cross" on the missiological stage of an American restorationist discourse. Behind the fine slogans and mottos emblazoned on that banner – *Restoration Plea / Ancient Order / Undenominational Christianity / Speak where the Bible speaks, and be silent where the Bible is silent / Call things by Bible names and do things the Bible way / In matters of faith, unity; in matters of opinion, liberty; in all matters, love* etc. – is the scandal of sectarianism and theological imperialism which has damaged individual identities and indigenous cultures.

The foregoing discussion has attempted to show how an American restorationist discourse "effects a dual subjection, that of speaking subjects to discourse, and that of discourse to the group, at least virtually, of speakers" (Foucault 1972: 226). It has striven to present how an apparently coherent, unproblematic epistemological system can reveal its own process of deconstruction from without and from within.

This article constitutes an appeal for indigenous communities to be more critical of cultural impositions clothed with the white garment of Evangelization

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and their divisive effects on our cultural ties. Religion must be, again to borrow from Ed Lapiz (1996: 109), "a sanctuary, not the cemetery, of Filipino [and other] cultural heritage".

Missionaries need to imbibe the spirit of other Christian scholars who could say:

> [We] are emerging into a postcolonial faith, a post-Western faith – not a faith that wants to forget and deny the many blessings of Christian faith in Western idioms, but a faith that no longer wants to be in denial about the dark sides of our history. We are emerging into a new era of Christian faith as a 'living color' global community, from a religion of conquest and control to a faith of collaborative mission and humble service. (McLaren 2007: 149–150).

For Filipino Christian missiologists, there is an "orientalism" that needs to be continually recaptured, one which helps us to strive to "understand and express the Christian faith through our Eastern cultural idioms and heritage" (Lapiz 1997: 119), just as the Jesuit priest Matteo Ricci did in his missionary work in China. This also means looking inward for models of change and adaptation in a world of religious fixation and faddism, as pointed out by Lapiz:

> Filipino Catholics are fixated on Rome. Muslims gaze at Mecca. Protestant, Baptist, Evangelical, and Mormon cultures are vintage Americana. Among the born-again Christians, the most recent choice of pilgrimage and feverish aping are the prayer mountains and mega churches of Korea. (Lapiz 1997: 138)

Joining the call for the interrogation of West-centric discourses does not necessarily mean being "Anti-West" or "Anti-American" for certainly many good things have come from the West. It is to say that not everything *Amerikano* must be imbibed by Filipinos; that conversion to Christianity need not mean "making [ourselves] less like Filipinos [or Chinese or Indians] and more like Americans in the process" (Scott 1989: 55). It is not to say that we must promote ethnolotry; it is to say that we must encourage ethnotheology. Far from just a lapse into nativism, this is an attempt of a native Filipino to place himself in that political space located (Chow 1996: 141), "between the defiled image and the indifferent gaze" "where a Brown Woman/Man stares indifferently, mocking [the cut-and-dried restorationists'] imprisonment within imagistic resemblance and [their] self-deception as the non-duped."

This, then, is a brown man's burden: disabusing himself of and deconstructing a constricting West-centric imperialist theological discourse, developing self-reflexivity in finding his subject position, and finding agency in a pluricultural arena of contestation.

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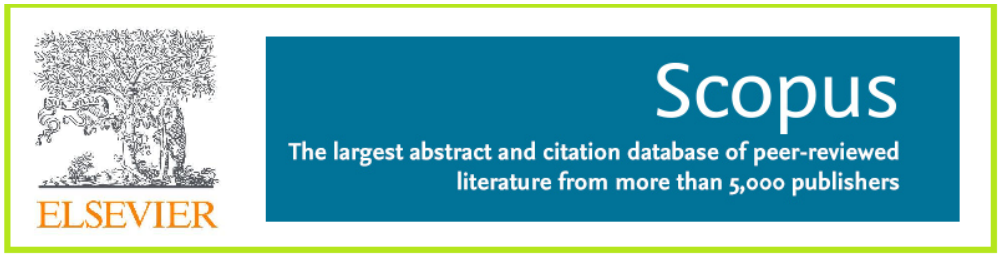
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